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Zechariah

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Zechariah

A. Overview and Summary.

1. The book of Zechariah was written by the prophet Zechariah as identified in Zechariah 1:1. Although one of the 12 minor prophets at the end of the Old Testament, New Testament writers reference it 40 times. The content is heavily Messianic, pointing to and prophesying about Christ. He is a contemporary of Haggai, and they both are mentioned in Ezra chapters 5 and 6. The empire of Babylon fell to the Medio-Persian empire in 539 BC under Cyrus the Great. Jews were allowed to return to Jerusalem; king Darius succeeded Cyrus in 522 BC. Since Zechariah says the word of the Lord came to him in the second year of Darius (Vs. 1:1), this would put the time of Zechariah's visions at 520 BC.
2. Zechariah's prophecies are wide in scope. They relate to the immediate rebuilding of the temple, but then move ahead to Christ's first coming, his second coming and then on to the Millennial kingdom. His writing style is similar to that of Daniel, as he writes about a series of visions that are apocalyptic. The reason he wrote, was to bring hope to the refugees that had come back to Jerusalem. Out of possibly one million Jews that lived in Babylon at the end of the captivity, only roughly 50,000 returned to Jerusalem. They faced opposition from the Samaritans and later, from Darius's successor. They had lapsed into apathy, fear and anxiety. The ministries of Haggai and Zechariah moved them out of that mindset into commencing the work of rebuilding the temple.
3. Chapters 1-8 are visions about rebuilding the temple. Chapters 9 through 14 are Messianic. Key chapters and verses are summarized below.

B. Chapter 1.

1. The word of the Lord came through Zechariah: "The LORD was very angry with your fathers. Therefore, say to them, thus declares the LORD of hosts: Return to me, says the LORD of hosts, and I will return to you, says the LORD of hosts" (Vs. 1:2-3). The Jews had returned to Jerusalem, but they needed to return to the Lord.
2. Zechariah's first vision is of a man on a red horse and three horses behind him in myrtle trees. The man is the angel of the Lord. He relates to Zechariah that they have returned from patrolling the earth and all is at rest. Through the angel, the Lord confirms His desire for Jerusalem: "Therefore, thus says the LORD, I have

returned to Jerusalem with mercy; my house shall be built in it, declares the LORD of hosts, and the measuring line shall be stretched out over Jerusalem. Cry out again, thus says the LORD of hosts: My cities shall again overflow with prosperity, and the LORD will again comfort Zion and again choose Jerusalem.” (Vs. 1:16-17).

3. Zechariah’s second vision is of four horns representing power of four nations that scattered Judah and Israel. Then four craftsmen come and break down the four horns. No explanation is given for which powers are the four horns. Certainly, Assyria is one of the horns as is Babylon. Nor is there explanation for the four craftsmen, but they represent four nations that break the four nations that scattered Judah and Israel.

C. Chapter 2. Zechariah sees a third vision of a man with a measuring line. Then the Lord gives him a vision of the restoration of Jerusalem under the Messiah: “Sing and rejoice, O daughter of Zion, for behold, I come and I will dwell in your midst, declares the LORD. And many nations shall join themselves to the LORD in that day, and shall be my people. And I will dwell in your midst, and you shall know that the LORD of hosts has sent me to you. And the LORD will inherit Judah as his portion in the holy land, and will again choose Jerusalem” (Vs. 2:10-12).

D. Chapter 3. Zechariah sees a fourth vision of Joshua, the high priest clothed in filthy garments. His filthy garments are removed and replaced with clean ones. The Lord then tells Joshua: “And the angel of the LORD solemnly assured Joshua, ‘Thus says the LORD of hosts: If you will walk in my ways and keep my charge, then you shall rule my house and have charge of my courts, and I will give you the right of access among those who are standing here. Hear now, O Joshua the high priest, you and your friends who sit before you, for they are men who are a sign: behold, I will bring my servant the Branch. For behold, on the stone that I have set before Joshua, on a single stone with seven eyes, I will engrave its inscription, declares the LORD of hosts, and I will remove the iniquity of this land in a single day. In that day, declares the LORD of hosts, every one of you will invite his neighbor to come under his vine and under his fig tree” (Vs. 3:6-10). The term “Branch” is another Messianic term, looking forward to when Messiah will reign.

E. Chapter 4. Zechariah sees another vision of a lampstand with seven bowls. An often-repeated verse is included in this chapter pertaining to the word of the Lord: “Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit, says the LORD of hosts” (Vs. 4:6b).

F. Chapters 5 through 8 continue the visions of Zechariah and pertain to the Lord's desire for Jerusalem's and Israel's restoration.

G. Chapter 9 is a profound prophecy that was fulfilled by Jesus upon His triumphal entrance into Jerusalem just before His crucifixion: "Rejoice greatly, O daughter of Zion! Shout aloud, O daughter of Jerusalem! Behold, your king is coming to you; righteous and having salvation is he, humble and mounted on a donkey, on a colt, the foal of a donkey" (Vs. 9:9). As discussed in Daniel chapter 9, this was a fulfillment to the very day of the 70th prophecy.

H. Chapter 10 addresses restoration for Judah and Israel.

I. Chapter 11.

1. Another profound prophecy is included pertaining to the betrayal of Jesus by Judas: "Then I said to them, 'If it seems good to you, give me my wages; but if not, keep them.' And they weighed out as my wages thirty pieces of silver. Then the LORD said to me, 'Throw it to the potter'—the lordly price at which I was priced by them. So, I took the thirty pieces of silver and threw them into the house of the LORD, to the potter'" (Vs. 11:12-13).
2. The chapter also includes a prophecy that has been tied to fulfillment in the last days associated with the antichrist: "Woe to my worthless shepherd, who deserts the flock! May the sword strike his arm and his right eye! Let his arm be wholly withered, his right eye utterly blinded!" (Vs. 11:17). The antichrist will recover from a major wound which gives him great acceptance by the people.

J. Chapter 12 includes more prophecies of end times.

1. "The burden of the word of the LORD concerning Israel: Thus declares the LORD, who stretched out the heavens and founded the earth and formed the spirit of man within him: 'Behold, I am about to make Jerusalem a cup of staggering to all the surrounding peoples. The siege of Jerusalem will also be against Judah. On that day I will make Jerusalem a heavy stone for all the peoples. All who lift it will surely hurt themselves. And all the nations of the earth will gather against it'" (Vs. 12:1-3).
2. Another profound prophecy concerning Christ's return is given: "And I will pour out on the house of David and the inhabitants of Jerusalem a spirit of grace and pleas for mercy, so that, when they look on me, on him whom they have pierced, they shall mourn for him, as one mourns for an only child, and weep bitterly over

him, as one weeps over a firstborn” (Vs. 12:10). Christ was pierced on the Cross for our sins.

K. Discussion, Application and Passing it on.

1. Zechariah contains profound prophecies of Christ’s first and second comings as well as His reign in the Millennial kingdom. Do you feel competent to be able to use these prophecies as examples of the validation of Scripture as God’s word to a skeptic?
2. The Jews had returned to Jerusalem, but they lapsed into apathy, anxiety and fear. How do you face life’s challenges? Is it apathy or anxiety and fear? How would what you have learned from the book of Zechariah help you to face these challenges?

This Old Testament survey was provided by Joshua Nations (JoshuaNations.org)